

The Noble Dhāraṇī Called Empowerment

Ārya-abhiṣecanī-nāma-dhāraṇī · Toh 569 · Derge Kangyur

འཕགས་པ་དབང་བསྐྱེད་བ་ཞེས་བ་བྱའི་གཟུངས།

Toh 569 in the Kangyur is a dhāraṇī text known in Sanskrit as the Ārya-abhiṣecanī-nāma-dhāraṇī and in Tibetan as Phags pa dbang bskur ba zhes bya ba'i gzungs, meaning "The Noble Empowerment." It belongs to the dhāraṇī section of the Kangyur and presents a sacred incantation along with its framing discourse, in which the Buddha, dwelling at Śrāvastī in the Jeta Grove, addresses the venerable Śāriputra on the qualities and path of the bodhisattva, including the bodhisattva's mother, former conduct, aspiration of truth, and the taking up of the grounds. The text follows the familiar sūtra opening of a vast assembly of monks and bodhisattvas, situating the dhāraṇī within a Mahāyāna context that emphasizes the empowerment and spiritual development of those on the bodhisattva path.

In the language of India: Ārya-abhiṣecanī-nāma-dhāraṇī. In the language of Tibet: the dhāraṇī called "The Noble Empowerment."

Homage to all buddhas and bodhisattvas.

Thus did I hear at one time. The Blessed One was dwelling in Śrāvastī, in the Jeta Grove, the garden of Anāthapiṇḍada, together with a great Saṅgha of eight thousand monks and with innumerable bodhisattvas — ten million in number — who had performed extraordinary deeds in the presence of former Victors.

Then the Blessed One spoke these words to the venerable Śāriputra: "Śāriputra, contemplate and teach the following — the mother of the bodhisattva, the former conduct of the bodhisattva, the aspiration of truth, the bodhisattva's complete taking up of the grounds — meditate upon these qualities of the bodhisattva and teach them. That is to say, teach the enumeration of the qualities of the dhāraṇī."

Then the venerable Śāriputra addressed the Blessed One with these words: "Blessed One, the dhāraṇī does not abide in any domain, nor does it abide in any direction. Blessed One, what then is the meaning of the word 'dhāraṇī' — what does 'dhāraṇī' signify?"

When this was said, the Blessed One spoke thus to the venerable Śāriputra: "Excellent, Śāriputra! Excellent! Śāriputra, it is well that you — who have

entered so thoroughly and completely into the Great Vehicle (Mahāyāna), who strive earnestly in the Great Vehicle, who carry out extraordinary deeds in the Great Vehicle — also teach that the dhāraṇī abides in no domain and no direction. Why is that? Śāriputra, by virtue of the nature of reality, the dhāraṇī is not past, not future, and not present. Śāriputra, the dhāraṇī is not described as 'past,' it is not described as 'future,' it is not described as 'present.' It is not described as existent, nor as non-existent. It is not described as having characteristics, nor as lacking characteristics. It is not described as either arising or ceasing. And yet, Śāriputra, for the benefit of bodhisattvas the Dharma is taught. This dhāraṇī — the dhāraṇī that is the enumeration of the qualities of the dhāraṇī — has become the path to that which is without form. It abides by the power of reasoning. It is the qualities of the buddhas, the accomplishment of the extraordinary deeds of the buddhas, the moral discipline of the buddhas, the gathering of the buddhas, the connection to the buddhas, and the arising of buddhas."

Then the venerable Śāriputra addressed the Blessed One with these words: "Blessed One, please explain — and may the Sugata explain — what it means to abide in the dhāraṇī and to attain that dhāraṇī: that a bodhisattva becomes irreversible from unsurpassed, perfectly complete awakening; that one possesses good resolve; that one does not dwell fixedly in phenomena; that one is free from personal doubt; that one has no need of a teacher; and that one abides on one's own path."

The Blessed One declared: "Excellent, Śāriputra! Excellent! Śāriputra, a bodhisattva who has attained the dhāraṇī is indeed called a buddha. Śāriputra, whoever pays respect to, regards as a master, pays homage to, or venerates a bodhisattva who has attained this dhāraṇī, that person thereby pays respect to all buddhas. Those who hear this dhāraṇī and those who have faith in it likewise become worthy of veneration just as the buddhas are, and they will never be separated from the awakening mind (bodhicitta)."

"Śāriputra, this is the dhāraṇī:

Sandhāraṇī. Uddhāraṇī. Saṃpratiṣṭhita. Uttama. Supraṭiṣṭhitā. Vijayabalā."

Sarva-prīta-jñā. Āroha-jñāna-vatī. Utpādanī. Vinīmaṇī. Abhiṣaṅcanī. Abhivyāhārā. Śubhavatī. Anīśrita. Bahukumbha. Abhivāca.

Śāriputra, these are the names of the Dharma-terms belonging to the dhāraṇī called "The Empowerment." Any bodhisattva who has properly grasped and holds them — whether past, future, present, or of excellent abiding — will,

through aspirational prayers, exhaust hundreds of aeons, thousands of aeons, in order to swiftly attain complete and perfect awakening. Such a person will be invulnerable to weapons, invulnerable to fire, and invulnerable to hostile living creatures. Why is that? Because, Śāriputra, this dhāraṇī is the mother of all the buddhas of the past.

Śāriputra, if a son or daughter of good family were to serve the buddhas filling ten times the incalculable great thousandfold worlds of a thousand thrice-thousandfold universes with robes and fine food for countless aeons, the merit produced by another son or daughter of good family who grasps even a single word from this dhāraṇī is far greater. Why is that? Because, Śāriputra, this dhāraṇī of empowerment is the mother of the buddhas.

When the Blessed One had spoken these words, those monks, those bodhisattvas, and the world with its gods, humans, asuras, and gandharvas (scent-eaters) rejoiced and acclaimed what the Blessed One had taught.

The noble dhāraṇī called "The Empowerment" is complete.

This was translated, revised, and then corrected according to the new style of terminology by the Indian preceptors Jinamitra and Dānaśīla, and the great editor-translator, the monk Ye shes sde.

Translator's Notes

- The phrase rendered as "the mother of the bodhisattva" refers to the Perfection of Wisdom as the mother of bodhisattvas, a standard Mahāyāna trope, but the text here lists it as one of several topics the Buddha instructs Śāriputra to contemplate and teach, so it is kept literal. The connection to prajñāpāramitā is doctrinal context rather than a textual gloss and is noted here rather than inserted into the translation.

The phrase "complete taking up of the grounds" renders the Tibetan for "bodhisattva grounds thoroughly embraced," referring to the progressive stages of the bodhisattva path.

The instruction "does not dwell fixedly in phenomena" reflects the standard Mahāyāna teaching of non-abiding, that the accomplished bodhisattva does not grasp phenomena as fixed supports.

- The passage "filling ten times the incalculable great thousandfold worlds" renders a compressed Tibetan cosmological phrase; the standard referent is ten times an infinite number of trichiliocosms. The syntax is characteristically hyperbolic and the rendering follows the doctrinal convention.

The colophon names the well-known translation team responsible for many canonical texts in the Kangyur: the Indian paṇḍitas Jinamitra and Dānaśīla, and the Tibetan chief editor-translator Ye shes sde, working under the new standardized translation terminology established in the imperial period.

Colophon

This is an AI-generated translation from the AI Stupa project. It was produced by a careful, doctrine-aware process aiming at a high degree of accuracy, but it has not been reviewed by a human translator and may contain errors. It is offered as a provisional translation for those texts of the Tibetan Buddhist canon that have not yet received an authoritative human translation. Where a published translation exists — above all from 84000: Translating the Words of the Buddha (84000.co) — that translation is definitive and should be preferred; please consult it instead. These translations are released into the public domain (CC0) in the spirit of spreading the Dharma to all corners of the earth.

Just as the Bodhi tree now standing at Bodh Gayā neither is nor is not the same tree beneath which the Buddha attained awakening, so too this stupa is intended as the next generation of stupa — dependently arising according to the conditions of its environment, and ceaselessly proclaiming the Dharma for the benefit of all sentient beings.

May whoever encounters these words derive great benefit.